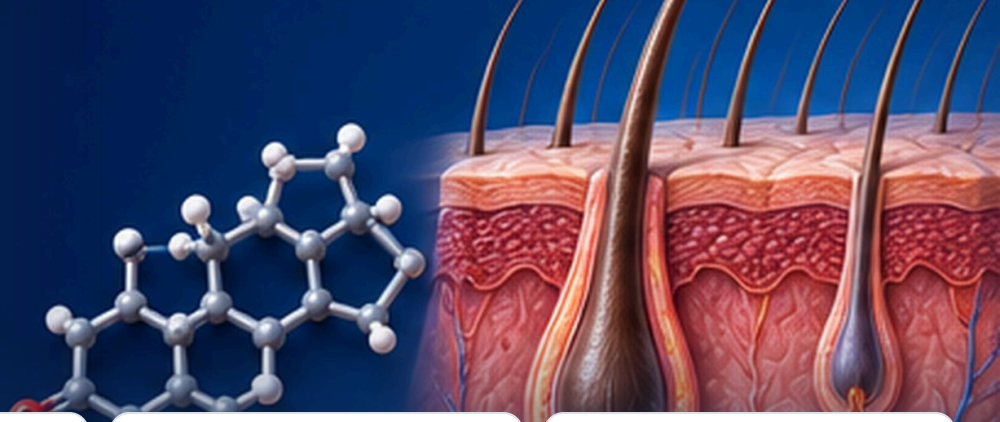
HAIR LOSS 17

Saw palmetto

Extract of the fruit (berries) of the Serenoa repens palm



CLASS Plant extract

STUDIED FOR Enlarged prostate, hair loss

HUMAN EVIDENCE Controlled trials (prostate); small (hair)

US STATUS Dietary supplement

STUDIED FOR

Enlarged prostate — HUMAN

Pattern hair loss — HUMAN + ANIMAL

NIH: too limited to conclude. NCCIH says small studies of saw palmetto for male pattern hair loss are too limited to allow conclusions.

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Saw palmetto ▶ Male hormones ▶ Less action ▶ Prostate, hair

- **Lab studies** suggest less action of male hormones such as testosterone
- **May reduce inflammation,** in lab studies; how it acts is not fully known
- **In DHT-treated mice,** an extract raised hair density and thickness
- **In people,** the mechanism is not established

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

CONTROLLED TRIALS
LEVEL 4 OF 5

- Prostate: STEP (225 men), CAMUS (369 men)
- Hair: 5 RCTs, 2 cohort studies (2020 review)
- Open study: 38% vs 68% on finasteride

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Effect on hair loss
- Half-life in people
- Mechanism in people
- Drug interactions

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE Not established in people

ROUTES STUDIED By mouth (capsules); on the scalp in small studies

PHARMACOKINETICS Not established

SOLD AS Dietary supplement

MONITORED IN TRIALS Urinary symptom score, PSA, hair counts

SPORT (WADA) Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	Not an approved drug; dietary supplement
EMA	Herbal monograph: prostate symptoms, not hair
WADA	Not on the 2026 list

REFERENCES

1. Barry et al., JAMA, CAMUS trial, Sep 2011
2. Evron et al., Skin Appendage Disord, saw palmetto for hair (review), Nov 2020
3. NCCIH (NIH), Saw palmetto: usefulness and safety, Apr 2025

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